

You will pay for that (part 2)

In May 2011, I wrote a column titled “You will pay for that”. It was a column about how piracy is slowly dying, but I left a thought unfinished “for another time”. That thought was about how the entertainment industry claims piracy has killed profits for everyone, and is akin to stealing. I’m returning to the topic, because recent developments suggest that this is indeed “another time”.

I want to start with piracy, and what it really does to the world. Think about the poor entertainers and the entertainment business as a whole – with millions of people stealing their precious creations, there are billions of dollars lost in potential sales. Is it fair that our beloved stars have to settle for smaller mansions and own fewer Bugatis or Ferraris? Aren’t they struggling enough? If we really think about it, if we paid those billions of dollars to legally buy their art, a few more African kids might end up being adopted by super-star parents. Now because you downloaded a movie that you’d rather not waste money on, or an album that you’d never really listen to anyway, this does not happen.

Shame on you...you scum of the earth, you...you...pirate!

Thankfully, over the past few months, a much-loved group of people (politicians) from the world’s largest democracy (us) and the world’s richest democracy (US) have started announcing what they think is needed to bring sense to the absolute chaos that is the internet. It’s about time someone stood up for the poor, starved of Caviar-and-Cuban-cigars,

entertainment industry guys, and stopped us pirates from ruining the world. After all, it’s the debauchery and excessiveness of our overtly-comfortable lives that’s bringing the world economy to its knees.

Our technology minister rightly gave Google and Facebook a proverbial rap on the knuckles when he demanded that they screen all our useless user generated content, and remove anything that’s illegal or objectionable. Who do these companies think they are anyway? Google can’t just keep sending spiders around the net to find everything. After all, some things just aren’t meant to be found. Similarly, Facebook can’t just allow us to go about saying and doing anything we like online – what if it offends someone important, questions a set belief or forces people to think for themselves? Can’t have that can we? After all, didn’t all those freedom fighters (who we’ve all but forgotten) dedicate their lives to fighting for our right to be silenced by the authorities?

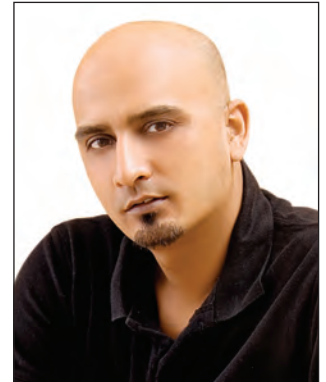
While India ponders over finding the right moral path online, in the US it’s a little more simplistic.

Many of you would have already read about SOPA (Stop Online Piracy Act), but for those who do not know, it’s an act that the US senate wants to introduce in order to prevent or control piracy online. There’s another act that’s also being presented called PIPA (PROTECT IP Act - Preventing Real Online Threats to Economic Creativity and Theft of Intellectual Property Act), which is similar. For those of you thinking, “Who cares

what they do in the US – I’m Indian!”, you should know that the US basically runs the Internet, and almost all major companies whose services you use on a daily basis are based in the US, so yes, this affects you too.

The US government wants to ban pirated material, or copyright infringement, or anything illegal that exists on the internet outside the US borders. Since foreign companies that host such content cannot be brought into a US court and sued, the US wants to be able to cut them off. It is demanding rights to be able to direct ISPs and their DNS servers, search engines such as Google, payment gateways such as PayPal and services such as AdSense to ignore, block and basically ban sites which the US government deems to have infringed on copyrights.

It’s not just about piracy of course, because if all goes as planned, those pesky little start-up businesses will rightfully suffer as well, because they’ll have to factor in the additional costs of policing user-generated content – comments, picture posts and videos. Thankfully, we’ll be able to create a monopoly for the existing biggies on the internet. It’s not like big companies are evil or anything... they’ll probably put social needs first, and protect the sanctity of the internet. Unlike those Occupy Wall Street protestors, standing in the way of progress, the magnanimous big corporations will help get you your entertainment fix, give you the latest gadgets at perfectly acceptable premium prices, and do a lot more good – make profits for their poor, hard-working investors, for example.



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

“The US government wants to ban pirated material, or copyright infringement, or anything illegal that exists on the internet outside the US borders”

And why shouldn’t the governments of the world look after the needs of the rich? After all, they pay more taxes, and are potential contributors to election campaigns...unlike us working class people who just create a mess, do all the dirty work, and vote these chaps into office.

Personally, I can’t wait for all the goodness that the governments in question will bring to the internet by controlling it. The net is way too popular for all the wrong reasons anyway – creativity, freedom, unrestricted thoughts, humour and intellect. Who needs that crap here in backwards-land, right?

Liked or hated this column? Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com, and express yourself.